Volume 2: Faceless

Chapter 322: The Thrilling Night

Klein found himself standing before a large black dog that was munching on the woman's internal organs. He created an illusion to attract the attention of the Devil dog before smashing through the glass window, as his preparations were not for this enemy, and a Magician never performed unprepared. The dog tried to curse him, but Klein used a Paper Substitute just in time. As Klein landed on the ground, he started screaming about a murder, waking up the residents of the entire area. This made the dog retreat from the window to clean up the scene of the crime, while Klein's figure disappeared from the street.

Klein appeared in a nearby fireplace, covered himself in extract to mask his scent from the dog's tracking abilities, then used the Master Key a few times. Once he was far enough, he hired a carriage to head to his apartment in East Borough. This situation made Klein fear the negative effects of the Master Key even more, as what were the odds of him getting lost and finding himself right next to the serial killer?

As he rode the carriage, pea vines suddenly surrounded it, but it seemed like only he could see them, as the driver kept going. Klein tried to escape or to burn the carriage, but his surroundings were abnormally quiet and nothing worked. The vines led the carriage up where he saw through the window a pair of black leather boots; it was the same woman from the museum, who he suspected was a High-Sequence Beyonder, but she didn't seem to recognize him without his disguise.

He told her that he was a private detective who was investigating the serial murders, and he told her about the Master Key which had gotten him lost into the scene of the crime, that was why he ran shouting for help. Everything he said was true, and he was glad he had left all mysticism-related items above the gray fog, as her gaze seemed to be penetrating the carriage and studying him. She just told him that the key had a curse before his surroundings returned to normal.

When he arrived, he went straight to sleep without even heading above the gray fog to investigate the bookmark; he knew the situation would be tense because of the murder. The next morning, the newspapers were all talking about the newest victim, with only some mention of an item being stolen from the museum. Klein returned home, prepared a hot bath and, once the vapor was thick enough, took four steps counterclockwise. He finally had his hands on Roselle's bookmark again.

Chapter 323: The Opening Incantation

He studied it carefully and noticed the hole Justice had left, confirming that this was the correct bookmark. It was time to figure out the password, or the opening incantation. He tried saying references from earth in multiple languages, but none worked. Reflecting on the wards from Roselle's diary, "the fated ones will receive it," Klein reached the conclusion it must have been something someone could say while coincidently holding this card, and they didn't necessarily have to be a Beyonder. This probably meant that each card had its own opening incantation.

As Klein immersed himself in Roselle's state of mind when he created this card, he first tried some curse words in different languages, then he shifted his focus to things Roselle would have been reluctant to part with, like his family. This led him to Bernadette, Roselle's eldest daughter. The password was her name.

The bookmark started absorbing Klein's energy as it changed into the form of a miniature book, with the cover being "Sequence 0, Black Emperor". It started flipping from Sequence 9 Lawyer, with a description of their abilities, along with the potion formula, to Sequence 5 Mentor of Disorder where rituals started appearing, then back to Sequence 0 Black Emperor.

[To advance from Sequence 1, the Prince of Abolition, to Black Emperor, the necessary ritual requires one to possess their own country, linking their name to the title of Emperor, making it common knowledge among the populace. Furthermore, one needed to establish a set of strict and complicated rules that defied normality, including architectural styles.

Then, they would spur on their citizens to secretly establish nine mausoleums that were similar to pyramids. After which, they would enter one of the mausoleums. With a large majority of the citizens who would be scattered across different cities in corresponding sacrificial rituals involved, the Prince of Abolition would imbibe the Sequence 0 potion.

Once the advancement was successful, the Black Emperor wouldn't truly die until all the nine secret mausoleums were destroyed. Even if "He" was annihilated, "He" would still be able to awaken and return from one of the mausoleums.

What was even more terrifying was that even if the deity was successfully killed and all nine mausoleums destroyed, as long as a certain amount of the order set up by that deity remained, it was still possible for "Him" to mysteriously revive. It appeared to be a loophole against death.

The best way to completely obliterate "Him" was for a new Black Emperor to appear!]

[In addition, Klein also knew one thing, once there was a True God with a Sequence 0, it was impossible for a Sequence 1 Beyonder to appear. If there was no Sequence 0, then, in the same way, there would be at most three Sequence 1 Beyonders. This was a result of the Law of Beyonder Characteristics Indestructibility and Conservation!

According to the Black Emperor Card of Blasphemy's description of the 10 Sequences, Klein could clearly see that the greatest feature of this pathway was the shadow of it gradually evolving into order!

Roselle also mentioned that if one had that Card of Blasphemy in hand after advancing to a High-Sequence Beyonder, the card would have a subtle reaction to the Beyonder ingredients that the person needed!

Of course, it was limited to High-Sequence Beyonders of the Black Emperor pathway.]

The card turned out to not be very useful to Klein, but at least he could exchange the formulas within it in Beyonder gatherings. Remembering Audrey's report last night, during which she had asked what was so special about this bookmark, The Fool finally responded, telling her that this was a Card of Blasphemy made by Roselle.

Chapter 324: Imagined and Real "Adorer"

Audrey didn't know what a Card of Blasphemy was, but she was able to connect the name to the Blasphemy Slates, which made her suspect just how important this actually was, and that was why The

Fool's blessed had asked for help in verifying it before making a move. She felt excited that the Tarot Club now possessed a complete pathway, and they could one day become the most powerful secret faction in the world. She learned from her father that there was another murder victim, and that this time, there was a witness who screamed for help, and that helped the police lock onto a suspect.

In the museum, the Machinery Hivemind Bryonders confirmed that only two bookmarks were missing, and that the aristocratic children who had visited after closing tome had no relation to the thief. They were able to reconstruct some parts of the scene, finding out why the bookmarks were stolen, and that there were two people who infiltrated that night.

After Klein returned to the real world, he started thinking about the events of the previous night. He believed that the mysterious lady wasn't an official Beyonder, otherwise she would have at least confiscated the Master Key if not imprisoned him outright. However, he had no guesses as to what secret organization she belonged to.

[*As for what happened in the museum, they will be searching for a special spirit body, a strange existence, and what has that got to do with me, Sherlock Moriarty?* Klein mocked himself as his heart grew calmer.]

As he was thinking about what to do next, Klein received a letter from Isengard Stanton.

Chapter 325: The Equestrian Teacher's Problem

Stanton wrote that Sherlock's hint was very useful, and that his guesses had been true. He also mentioned how the most likely suspect of one of the older cases, before his death, had owned a large black dog that had later disappeared, with its new owner remaining unknown. This letter meant that the official Beyonders were on the right track, and the way it was written implied that Stanton understood that Sherlock knew the exact truth about the murderer.

After writing a short reply where he acted innocent, Klein headed to the Quelaag Club. There, he encountered Talim, an aristocratic equestrian teacher and one of the two who recommended Sherlock to the club.

[Talim nodded gently and said hesitantly, "I have a friend who has fallen in love with someone he shouldn't have. How should he deal with such a situation?"

Although I had always believed that anyone who asks a question prefaced with "I have a friend" basically means "I myself," Talim's emotional colors implies that it's not for himself. He's in a dilemma, but I can't see any traces of pain... After activating his Spirit Vision, Klein leaned back slightly, clasped his hands, and said, "I'm sorry, but I'm not a psychiatrist or any of the experts in the newspapers or magazines who are good at solving emotional problems.

"My only advice is not to break the law. Heh heh, that was a joke. First, we need to understand how this 'shouldn't have' arose. Is there a feud between the family?"

Talim glanced at him and said in resignation, "No, this isn't Romeo and Juliet!"

Upon hearing Talim's reply, Klein seemed to hear an illusory murmur in his ears. *Author: Roselle Gustav... Author: Roselle Gustav... Author: Roselle Gustav...* Shaking his head, he apologized to Shakespeare and smiled.]

They couldn't reach a solution, so Klein just headed to the shooting range before paying a visit to the buffet cafeteria (A one-person meal this time, thankfully). While he was looking for a place to sit, he noticed Aaron Ceres, the surgeon who had recommended him, with a crutch. He learned that Aaron had been suffering from bad luck lately and had fallen down the stairs.

["Do you know anyone who's like a village witch doctor? No, I mean, some of the more capable fortune-tellers or mysticism enthusiasts. I think... I feel that my recent string of bad luck is too abnormal... I know it's likely to be a fake or a scam, but there's no other way of shirking my bad luck. I've tried to go to church, praying, donating, attending Mass, but it didn't work at all."

Capable fortune-teller and mysticism enthusiast... You seem to be talking about me... Klein pondered and said, "Aaron, tell us in detail about what happened to you."]

Chapter 326: "Professional" Suggestion

After some questioning, Klein learned that Aaron had a young patient whose leg had to be amputated. That child loved to play with tarot cards and Aaron had once joined him. That day, he had pulled the reversed Wheel of Fortune, and the child told him that his luck would get worse. But the child had safely made it out of the operation, so he didn't think much of it.

Klein casually flipped a coin in his hand, glanced at it, then asked about the boy's name. It was Will Auceptin. Klein advised him to report his misfortune to the church he believed in, hoping this abnormality would reach the Nighthawks.

[At this moment, Aaron had already made up his mind. He looked at Klein and grinned. "Thank you, Mr. Moriarty. Although you don't know mysticism, you relied on strict logic to provide the best suggestion."

Yes, I don't know mysticism... Klein smiled.]

Later, Klein headed to a circus in the hopes of finding inspiration for his acting by watching magicians perform. He bought a ticket and entered the tent to find it time for the beast tamer's performance. A member of the audience kept shouting about how the animals wanted to harm their master and, while the rest of the audience considered these to be mocking jokes, Klein detected a hint of warning in the speaker's tone. As he looked over to the man who was yelling, he thought him quite familiar.

Chapter 327: Encounter on the Road

Using his abilities, Klein was able to recall that this man was the Apothecary who attended the Eye of Wisdom's gathering. The beast tamer actually took the man's warnings into account, and the show passed with no incidents. When it was the magician's turn, he performed some classic tricks.

[*He clearly doesn't have any Beyonder powers, but his technique is still able to fool my eyes. Hmm, the key point is grasping attention... The Magician's second principle is fully divert a target's attention, thus*

achieving the desired effect? Klein made a guess in his mind which he wasn't sure if it was right or wrong. It needed him to "act" it out to receive feedback.

At this moment, the magician's performance came to an end. The audience weren't stingy with their warm applause and cheers. The atmosphere in the theater reached its peak that afternoon.

Heh heh, the third principle. A Magician's performance requires the applause of the audience for his performance? Klein muttered to himself in a half-joking and half-guessing manner in silence.]

Klein didn't attempt to make contact with the Apothecary, so he just took a public carriage to leave. On the way, he suddenly became lucid, and he immediately realized he was no longer in the real world. Everything around him looked the same, but his Spirit Vision showed that none of the people around him were real.

Outside the carriage, the Devil dog appeared along with a few people that weren't illusions. Klein concluded that they must be under the effect of a Sealed Artifact that only affected Beyonders, while normal people wouldn't be able to see any of this. The large dog was quickly annihilated, and Klein was worried that the official Beyonders would now discover him, someone who wasn't an illusion like the other normal people. He pulled out a Paper Figurine and substituted it with himself, hiding himself in its "shadow". He only returned to normal once he was sure he had returned to the real world. He was surprised at just how quickly the dog was found and executed, despite his ability to sense danger in advance. The last thing he noticed were traces of someone else having been present, possibly the dog's companion.

Chapter 328: He That Touches Pitch Shall Be Defiled

Klein waited a few stops before disembarking, making a detour, and returning to the area where the battle had taken place; he wanted to see if he could gather any information about the Sealed Artifact that was used. Unfortunately, there were no traces left, and all Klein could guess was the range of its effect. In the evening, on his way home, Klein remembered that he had no ingredients at home, and he really didn't want to go get groceries, then cook, then wash the dishes, so he just decided to eat out.

Lawyer Jurgen caught sight of the indecisive Klein and once again invited him to have dinner with them. As the two ate, Klein learned that Jurgen's grandmother had been admitted to the hospital, as the weather had brought back some of her chronic issues.

[ ]

[ ]

[When he passed by the Sammers, he saw through the oriel window that the interior was brightly lit. People were moving back and forth, and sounds of chatter and laughing could be heard.

As for next door, 15 Minsk Street (his own place), it was dark and silent. With a sigh, Klein quickened his pace, took out his key, and opened the door.]

Klein found a new letter in his mailbox from Isengard Stanton, which told him that the murderer had been caught and killed on the spot, and that Stanton would contact him when it was time to issue the

reward. With the serial murder situation settled, he could head to the Bravehearts bar and find Sharron and Maric, who he suspected were defectors of the Rose School of Thought, and have them teach him some of the mysticism he hadn't gotten the chance to learn before his death.

Chapter 329: Claw Marks

At the bar, Klein learned that Kaspars had been chased out of there, and his business had been snatched away by someone else. As he was taken to meet the new boss, Klein found him hanging. As gang members started freaking out over their boss's death, Klein followed his divinations and spiritual intuition out of the bar, with the smell of blood getting stronger as he walked. He was met a gruesome scene of scattered human organs and limbs, with what seemed to be claw marks on the nearest wall.

Klein suspected that whoever killed the gang's boss was finished off here as he tried to escape, and that this was done by a werewolf of the Prisoner pathway, likely a trap set by the Rose School of Thought for Kaspars and his people in the hopes of getting to Sharron and Maric. As he walked away to find someone to report this scene to the police, a carriage stopped in front of him; in it sat Maric and Sharron. As Klein told them about his intention to purchase mysticism books from them, they said that their price would be his help.

Chapter 330: Sharron and Maric's Philosophy

[Of course, this wasn't to say that he would give up on exchanging information with The Sun and The Hanged Man. By having knowledge from ancient times, orthodox knowledge, and secret and unorthodox knowledge, it would result in him being more all-rounded, giving him a deeper understanding of mysticism!

And that was exactly what Klein wanted.

He had never forgotten that his ultimate goal was to return to Earth, so the more mysticism knowledge he had, the better. The more comprehensive, the better; the deeper the knowledge was, the better it was!

Of course, the premise of pursuing this goal is to get rid of Ince Zangwill, and avenge myself and the Captain... Klein looked at Sharron and Maric and said with the corners of his mouth curled up, "I need to know what kind of help you need from me before I can consider agreeing. I won't, nor is it possible for me to joke about my life."]

Maric explained how the two of them belonged to a secret organization that believed in an evil being and focused on releasing their desires through cruel sacrifices. Sharron and Maric couldn't accept their cruelty, and so they ran away.

[The blonde and black-dressed Sharron replied in an ethereal voice, "The way they do it is to indulge and burn. Our philosophy is to repress and show temperance."

So that's how it is... Klein suddenly thought of the description of the Prisoner Sequence. The body was the cage of the heart, and the world was the cage of the body. Madness was bound, and desire was suppressed.

If the Rose School of Thought did grasp the Mutant pathway of Prisoner, Miss Sharron's and Maric's philosophy is clearly more suited to the needs of the acting method. Why couldn't the other members notice this? That's not right... He frowned slightly.]

["They were influenced by that evil god, and they believe that indulging in their desires would help to strengthen their own willpower... …Our views are the exact opposite. We believe that desire must always be suppressed in one's heart, just like the flames and magma underground. Only at a crucial moment can it be unleashed, producing terrifying power."]

Seeing as they decided to face their pursuers instead of just leaving Backlund, Klein guessed that they must have had something they wanted there. As for him, he had the formulas up to his Sequence 5, so he could leave. He decided to stay in Backlund for a while longer because it was full of Beyonders and gatherings that he could make use of. It would only be after he advanced to Faceless that he would head out to see in preparation for his Sequence 5 ritual.

[Sharron replied calmly, "Be our support. To kill a Sequence 5 Beyonder, together."

Klein was slightly surprised as he asked, "With your strength, that organization only sent one Sequence 5 Beyonder to hunt you down?"]

["He has a Sealed Artifact that greatly restrains me," Sharron answered calmly, her face pale but her expression delicate. "The person in charge of this matter is indeed a High-Sequence Beyonder."

"But he has been led elsewhere by the clues that we deliberately left behind," Maric added. "It's not like we only have Backlund as our only base. If we can kill the person in charge of the nearby boroughs and take away that Sealed Artifact, we will immediately disguise ourselves and flee. After that, we will no longer be afraid of being hunted down normally."]

They wanted Sherlock Moriarty's help because Sharron believed he was special, not just a regular Sequence 9 Beyonder, and they wanted him to use the black eye in his possession to find their opponent, who had similar traits to Sharron.

Chapter 331: The Accursed

Maric talked about their pathway's Sequence 9 Prisoner (with strong bodies and keen senses, they can kill with whatever they get their hands on), Sequence 8 Lunatic (they can completely let go of rationality and enter an enhanced state), and Sequence 7 Werewolf (strong rejuvenation, speed, agility, and physical strength. Their claws and teeth are venomous and can be used to put someone under their control), where the mutations began. He then talked about his own Sequence 6 Zombie (a bullet would have to hit the same spot 5 times to get through his defenses, and he could only be killed if his brain was destroyed. He could also wield death-related spells like summoning zombies), and Sharron's Sequence 5 Wraith (able to transform into an actual wraith with the corresponding abilities, can possess others, and remain undetectable to anyone who wasn't at a high Sequence).

[*It sounds like my nemesis. I'm precisely afraid of the type who are impervious to revolver bullets and do not suffer immense damage when burned by ordinary flames... Simply put, I'm afraid of "ghosts"...* Klein felt his heart thump a little.]

As for the Sealed Artifact in the enemies' possession, it could simulate the effects of a full moon which, for those who always indulged in their desires, would make them much stronger. As for those who always suppressed their desires, like Sharron and Maric, they would grow weaker and be left in a lot of pain.

["The person who wears the Scarlet Lunar Corona is immune to the effects of the full moon, and they will gain terrifying speed and unimaginable rejuvenation abilities, as well as a number of relatively powerful darkness-related spells. However, it will make the wearer's blood gradually turn cold. They will freeze up, bit by bit, and if they do not stop in time or drink the blood of a living person, they will ultimately die as their blood freezes up completely."]

Their pursuers were a Wraith, a Zombie, and a Werewolf. If they could stop them, Maric would get the Wraith characteristic, Sharron would take the Sealed Artifact, while Klein would get any other spoils along with a mysticism book just as he wanted.

Chapter 332: Notary Certificate

Klein told them he would have to think about it, and they only let him go after making him promise not to divulge their secrets while pressing his hand on a Notary Certificate. He went about his day normally just in case Sharron was watching, and woke up around four in the morning to head above the gray fog. There, he performed some divinations to know whether he should accept the commission and just how dangerous it would be, receiving acceptable revelations. He made up his; this would be a grand performance for this new Magician, so he brought everything he needed to the real world.

The next morning, at the exact time he had told Sharron to come hear his answer, Klein spoke out into the emptiness of his own home, saying that he would accept the mission on the condition that they gave him a few days to prepare. Despite him not being able to see anyone, he heard Sharron's voice as she agreed and told him to go to the bar once he was ready.

Chapter 333: The Tracker

Elsewhere, Audrey attended a Beyonder gathering with Fors, Xio, and Viscount Glaint, where she asked for the Spectator formula, to no avail. As they were leaving, Xio could sense that someone was following them, but they acted normal as each went their own way. Audrey suspected that the person following them was a member of the Psychology Alchemists who was suspicious of her request, and might be considering recruiting her into their organization.

Meanwhile, Klein was leisurely spending time in the Quelaag club, playing some card games, and checking on Lawyer Jurgen's cat, Brody. When it was time, he put on a hood and mask and attended the Eye of Wisdom's gathering.

Chapter 334: Bullets

At the gathering, he was able to exchange one of the formulas he had obtained from the Black Emperor card for fifty bullets with different effects along with a gun. But when he asked about a mystical item

from the Sun domain that could purify wraiths and shadows, he got no answer. He wasn't worried, however, as he already had things he could exchange if someone found a suitable item, or he could find a way to reach out to the Beyonder Xio had recruited to "purify" her after she had chanted The Fool's Honorific Name.

Close to the end of the gathering, someone requested an ingredient that Klein knew was for Sequence 6 of the Demoness pathway.

Chapter 335: Exploring Verdi Street

Klein was left confused at the buyer being a man, suspecting that he wasn't the one who needed the ingredient; perhaps he was helping someone who had lost her connection to the Demoness Sect, as that secret organization wasn't lacking in ingredients. Klein thought about tailing the man after the gathering, but he found it unnecessary and not worth the risk.

No one responded, and the gathering continued as usual. After everyone left, Klein headed to his rented apartment in East Borough where he loaded his new gun and tested how it felt in his hands. He then did some preparations before heading to the address where the thief had found the Master Key.

He easily entered the second floor through a balcony that was left open, probably by the thief. He was met with a messy corridor, with all doors left ajar, and the corpse of what he suspected to be another burglar who wasn't as lucky as the one who found the Master Key. There was nothing valuable left, so he headed for the stairs.

As he descended, he found himself met with the same corridor he was just in. Klein kept going down from the second floor only to find himself back on the second floor. Suddenly, a coldness enveloped him as if something possessed his body, and his hands tried to twist his own neck. He suppressed himself enough to take out Azik's copper whistle and throw it, attracting the attention of whatever had just tried to kill him. As it ran after the whistle, Klein shot it with a Purifying Bullet.

Klein picked up the whistle and checked for any other wraiths or shadows, then headed straight to the basement that he had seen in his divination of the Master Key.

Chapter 336: The Abraham Family

All Klein found was a notebook with details about the Abraham family: how they were once a powerful family in the Fourth Epoch's Tudor Dynasty whose glory fell after the War of The Four Emperors and the disappearance of one of their ancestors named Bethel. How they became cursed, with all of them losing control at Sequences 8 or 7, leading them to separate into groups and live far apart from each other. And how some of them started choosing to remain ordinary humans instead of becoming Beyonders.

Klein suspected that this "Bethel Abraham" was Mr. Door, whose cries for help ended up becoming a curse for his family, though how exactly that connected to Fors, who wasn't an Abraham, remained unconfirmed. As he continued reading, he learned the formulas for Sequence 9 Apprentice, Sequence 8 Trickmaster, and Sequence 7 Astrologer. He speculated that the Seer and Apprentice pathways could be exchanged at higher sequences, thanks to the similarities between them.

The owner of the notebook had then written that he would consume the Apprentice potion on the night of the full moon, and Klein was stunned at his ignorance, immediately realizing why the man had died on the spot. This also explained the curse on the Master Key that would make one lose their way; it was an item formed by and Apprentice's characteristic that was affected by Mr. Door's ravings.

After erasing any traces of himself, Klein left and went back home. There, he transmitted The Magician a message notifying her that The World had obtained the Trickmaster formula, and that he wanted an artifact from the Sun domain in exchange.

Chapter 337: The Search for A Missing Person

Fors was ecstatic, and her mind immediately thought of the Sun pathway Beyonder that Xio had hired for purification, though she started considering whether she would have to borrow money to be able to by the item The World wanted, with him promising to pay for the difference. As for Klein, he visited Leppard to check on the progress of the bicycle before heading to Isengard Stanton's house to collect the reward for the serial murders case.

Stanton named Sherlock Moriarty as a brilliant detective with the biggest contribution in solving this case, offering him the highest portion of the bounty. This clearly changed the way the other detectives viewed him, as it wasn't everyday someone earned such praise from Stanton. After the bounty was distributed, Stuart asked for Sherlock's help in keeping an eye out for a missing person, giving him a portrait. The missing man's name was Emlyn White. (*Isn't that the name of the vampire who's imprisoned in the basement by Father Utravsky?*)

Elsewhere, Audrey was attending a tea party with other nobles when one of the ladies found a chance to talk to her in private. The woman mentioned that she had heard Audrey was interested in mysticism.

Chapter 338: The Experienced Klein

The lady told Audrey that she knew some mysticism experts and that she could introduce her to them during afternoon tea the following day, and Audrey agreed, all-the-while acting like an excited, naïve girl who still didn't know much about the world of Beyonders. As the woman left, Audrey noted how she seemed nervous, suspecting her of being a member of the Psychology Alchemists, though she didn't seem to catch onto the fact that Audrey herself was a Telepathist.

Meanwhile, Klein was not willing to involve himself with Emlyn White, but of course he didn't tell Stuart about that. As they were leaving, Stanton warned Sherlock that there might have been another, more ferocious person behind the killer, so he had to keep his contribution a secret for his own safety.

After going home, Klein headed above the gray fog to divine what changes could happen to the Master Key under the effects of the full moon (*I'm courting death again...*). He heard sharp ravings that made him feel immense pain, and he woke up from the dream divination. It seemed that being in contact with the key during the full moon would allow him to hear Mr. Door, though Klein didn't dare to try before becoming a High-Sequence Beyonder. For now, what he heard made him confirm that Mr. Door was pleading for help.

Returning to the real world, Klein went to the Bravehearts bar, where he noted that Kaspars was back, before leaving and taking a carriage. Moments later, Sharron appeared in front of him, asking whether he was ready, telling him that she possessed a mystical item that could prove useful. He replied that he wasn't ready yet, but he had a sedative that might be able to help Maric suppress the effects of the full moon on him, but they would have to test that during the following day's full moon. If it worked, it could prove beneficial during their battle against the Rose School of Thought's Beyonders and their mystical item.

Chapter 339: Psychiatrist

["No problem. I hope that this cooperation will not only go smoothly but also be enjoyable." Klein habitually leaned forward to shake hands.

Sharron lowered her head to take a look, and her figure gradually faded into the air.

Klein continued his motion and raised his right hand to smooth his black hair, laughing dryly in the process.]

On his way home, Klein noticed that Jurgen place was dark. So, with the key he had been given, he entered to feed the cat.

[Klein squatted down and tried to touch Brody's head, but Brody quickly moved back and flung his hand away in disgust.]

[Klein glanced at it, rehearsing the shredding of chicken breast in his mind while he chatted with Brody, "You must miss Mrs. Doris, right? Are you worried about her condition...Lawyer Jurgen didn't come home today. Are you feeling lonely and uncomfortable on your own? Do you feel like you lack a sense of belonging and are exhausted..."

As he spoke, Klein's voice slowly faded into silence. Brody the black cat remained sitting there, quietly watching him. It didn't make any noise, nor did it cry out.]

At a noble tea party, Audrey was introduced to a man named Alucard and a woman named Escalante, who were a psychologist and psychiatrist. She kept up the innocent act as she carefully selected what questions to act to maintain her image and not let them know that she was already a Beyonder. However, they left without mentioning the Psychology Alchemists at all, leaving Audrey rather disappointed, though she reasoned that recruitment would need a period of observation. It was suggested, however, that she ask Escalante to be her teacher, as Audrey seemed interested in psychology.

On Sunday morning, Klein found that the map of Backlund that he had left on the table had been marked by Sharron, showing him several places that her and Maric were considering for their battle against their pursuers. He familiarized himself with all locations and their surroundings before heading to the Quelaag club in the afternoon. There, he encountered Aaron Ceres, who told him that praying at the church had worked, and he was no longer as unlucky as he had previously been.

Chapter 340: Past

After some small talk, Klein left for the shooting range, where he encountered two more acquaintances: Madam Mary (the one who hired him for proof of her husband's cheating), and Stelyn Sammer (his neighbor and landlady). Mary had to greet some other friends, leaving Klein and Stelyn to talk about any recent events.

["What did the murderer look like? Why did he kill those ladies? The newspapers had been very vague."

"I'm sorry, I have to comply with the confidentiality clause." Klein deftly made up an excuse.

It's not like I can tell you that it had a body of black fur; a smooth, glistening tail; and that it likes to run on all fours... Klein lampooned inwardly.]

Of course, she asked about how much he earned, and Klein's response was very vague. She then invited him to a party she would be hosting the following week, stating that she could introduce him to some nice ladies from good families. Klein told her he'd try to come in an effort to maintain a good relationship with his neighbors.

At night, as the full moon appeared, Klein heard an illusory voice. He took four steps counterclockwise and summoned The Magician, though he made no effort to strike up a conversation; that wouldn't befit the image of the mysterious Mr. Fool. Fors, however, was very obviously uncomfortable, so he asked her how she became a Beyonder.

She rambled on about how she used to be a doctor, but had to watch helplessly as her mother succumbed to illness, while her father had left them for work but started a new family and never came back, and Klein, who had nothing better to do, listened silently.

She kept focusing on her work until an old woman came to see her and became a regular patient. Fors felt sympathetic for the woman who was childless and had lost her husband years prior, so she often accompanied her, learning that the old lady could walk through walls using something her husband had left her. The woman said that she could use it without suffering from the curse as she wasn't a member of some family.

On her death bed, the old woman asked Fors whether she wanted to be like her, Fors agreed and was given the formula and instructed to take the characteristic that would appear once she died. She also left her a bracelet, telling her not to use it unless she was in absolute danger, and to not pay attention to the ravings during the full moon. After using the bracelet once, the full moon's ravings became unbearable for Fors. The Fool told her that they would no longer have much of an effect on her once she became a High-Sequence Beyonder.

The following morning, Klein found a piece of paper telling him that the sedative he had given Maric was effective. Then he started preparing for the Tarot gathering.

Chapter 341: Private Communication

As the gathering started, Audrey greeted The Fool as usual before asking to report something to him privately, telling him about her recent encounters with what she suspected to be the Psychology Alchemists. As they weren't and evil organization, Klein agreed to let her join them, telling her to seek

help from the Tarot Club if she ever encountered any issues. He also told her that among the Psychology Alchemists, there were people planted by official Beyonders, so she would have to conceal herself.

[*Mr. Fool is so nice to remind me to be careful...* Audrey slightly bent her eyes and replied with a shallow smile, “In the future, there will also be an informant from the Tarot Club inside the Psychology Alchemists.”

...Miss Justice, you haven’t even joined, and you’re already thinking of betraying them... Klein silently drew an invisible crimson moon for the Psychology Alchemists.]

She also took this chance to give him the two pages of Roselle’s diary that she had memorized while Fors couldn’t see her, they were the same ones Klein had seen at the Memorial Exhibition in the museum but he still had to reward her. All Justice wanted to know was which pathway the Card of Blasphemy at The Fool’s side belonged to. He told her it was the Black Emperor, whose Sequence 9 was Lawyer, and the private conversation ended.

The Magician promised The World that she would tell him what mystical items she could find no later than the following day, so if he didn’t like them, he would ask for something else in exchange for the Trickmaster formula. In that case, Klein was thinking of purchasing the Sealed Artifact that Eye of Wisdom had introduced to him a few gatherings prior (refer to volume 2 part 1, chapter 257, paragraph 3).

Alger then reported that he was investigating a case of many people from the Southern Continent disappearing, with this possibly being related to slave trade. None of the other members had more clues to offer him. Observing their silence, he instead asked them to help him find the formula for his next advancement; Sequence 6 Wind-Blessed. Once he was done, Derrick announced that he was assigned to a mission to explore the temple of the True Creator that the City of Silver had recently found, and that the leader of this mission was Shepherd Elder Lovia.

Chapter 342: The Old Fox Alger

The Sun gave more context by describing what was known about the temple from its discovery: aside from the statue of the True Creator, there were also a few murals that depicted him saving his believers from the “end of days,” with one of these murals showing words that, when deciphered, said “Rose Redemption”. It was speculated that this was either a code name used by the artist of the murals, or the name of the organization that built the temple.

He also mentioned that these murals seemed to be a thousand years old, though he wasn’t sure how long that was for the others, as the City of Silver measured its days by the frequency of lightning due to the absence of the sun and moon. The mission Derrick was assigned to was the exploration of the underground parts of the temple.

Alger’s advice was for Derrick to refuse the mission, especially since its leader was Shepherd Elder Lovia, whose pathway fell under the control of the True Creator. This was an evil deity whose temple – even if abandoned – could contain abnormal danger that was difficult to detect.

[*Your suggestion is the same as mine, but it doesn’t require The Sun to describe the half-destroyed temple. You could’ve come up with this conclusion with the conditions at the beginning... I understand.*

Mr. Hanged Man, you were doing it on purpose. This way, you got a rough idea of the state of the temple without paying anything... You're really just bullying a little kid... Sitting at the end of the table, Klein leisurely reached out his hand to support his forehead.]

As the mission was compulsory, Alger suggested for Derrick to deliberately let a monster injure him while out on patrol so that he would be left behind to heal, but Derrick hadn't been assigned to patrol. The Hanged Man then suggested for him to push himself to the brink of losing control, in which case he would be quarantined and given medicine until his state improved.

[Alger changed his seating posture as he leaned back.

"This mission carries immense risk. This is something you know. If you die in that half-destroyed temple, then who will be able to find a way to expose the strangeness of Shepherd Lovia? Who can save the City of Silver from this crisis? The Fallen Creator is a real evil god! You are not pretending to lose control or lying to others for your own personal interests. You are doing so to save the City of Silver! …"]

After some convincing, Derrick agreed. Then, The World requested a private exchange with The Sun, during which he asked him whether the City of Silver had a way of purifying a Beyonder characteristic. He said that they did, but he wasn't of a high-enough rank to be privy to such information.

Chapter 343: By Oneself

That night, Fors attended Mr. A's gathering on her own, hoping to purchase an artifact of the Sun domain for The World. She got an offer for one, though it was way too expensive and really not even that good. Excusing herself to the bathroom, she prayed to The Fool to inform him of what she found, and Klein used The World to tell her not to buy it. Instead, he would just exchange the Trickmaster formula with her for some cash.

This left Klein with that person at the Eye of Wisdom's gathering who had promised to help him look. Otherwise, he would purchase the item that the Eye of Wisdom himself had offered. Fors didn't linger in the gathering, as her intuition told her that there was something different about Mr. A, and that he was much more dangerous now.

In the City of Silver, Derrick was contemplating warning the Council of Elders about the True Creator and his pathway. The issue would be that he would have to explain how he knew all of that, and he couldn't exactly tell them about The Fool. He just settled on the plan The Hanged Man had suggested and started to push himself to the brink of losing control. Meanwhile, Audrey talked to her mother and who agreed to hire Escalante to be her psychology tutor.

On Tuesday, Klein confirmed that the Eye of Wisdom would be holding a gathering the following night, so he decided to relax at the Quelaag club.

Chapter 344: Spending Lavishly

At the Quelaag club, Klein ran into Talim Dumont, who informed him that the reporter Mike Joseph had wanted to hire Sherlock Moriarty to be his bodyguard, and he would come to discuss the details within the following few days. Klein made no promises, as he wasn't sure when the mission with Sharron and

Maric would be. Then, Fors sacrificed the money and received the Trickmaster formula, leaving her motivated to write a new book so that she could earn enough money to purchase the ingredients she needed.

The following evening, at the Eye of Wisdom's gathering, Klein wasn't satisfied with the weapon offered to him, so he sold the Sequence 7 Briber (form the Black Emperor pathway) for cash, and instead chose to purchase the brooch that the Eye of Wisdom possessed.

(Artifact name: Sun Brooch. Power level: equivalent to a weaker Grade 2 Sealed Artifact. Abilities: strong purification of the undead within a certain radius and weakening the more powerful spirits. Makes the wearer resistant to possession and corruption, and allows them to cast multiple Sun-related spells. Negative effect: the wearer always experiences a feeling of intense heat that could leave them irritated or even on the brink of losing control)

Chapter 345: Sun Brooch

After confirming the item and paying for it, Klein didn't think about buying anything else for the rest of the gathering; most of his savings were already gone. After it was done, he circled the Bravehearts bar before taking a carriage and, as expected, Sharron appeared on the opposite seat. He told her that his preparations were ready, and asked her to prepare some explosives and bury them around the planned battlefield, though he didn't elaborate on his plan.

The next morning, Mike visited Klein, telling him that he was doing some investigations in East Borough over the weekend and needed a bodyguard just in case. Klein asked him to come again the following day; if he confirmed that he was free, he would take the mission. Otherwise, he could introduce him to other detectives like Stuart or Kaslana.

[*Finally, a normal mission... It neither involves Beyonders nor does it have anything to do with finding cats and catching adulterers. It's a pity that it isn't a commission regarding a murder case or something like that. Otherwise, I would be able to experience what it feels like to be a true detective... There is always only one truth (this is a catchphrase from Detective Conan)!* Klein's thoughts wandered aimlessly as he felt an inexplicable sense of carefreeness.

If not for the fact that he was still worried about the situation regarding Sharron and Maric, he planned to relax completely, visit all kinds of museums, buy a ticket to a large theater, listen to a few operas and musicals, and enjoy the delicacies of the various nations that had gathered in Backlund city.

Well, I'm a casual tourist, a lonely gourmet... Klein gave a self-deprecating laugh, turned around, and walked towards the sofa, intending to look through the newspapers he hadn't finished reading.

Suddenly, he noticed that a slip of paper had appeared on the coffee table. The handwriting was elegant and reserved: "Tonight at 10 o'clock. We'll meet at the back door of Bravehearts Bar."

Klein was stunned for a moment. He turned his head to look outside the window, sighed, and said, *Is it finally starting...*]

Chapter 346: A Magician Before Going Onstage

At 10 PM, Klein circled the Bravehearts bar before finding a carriage stopping for him; in it were Maric and Sharron. Klein gave Maric the rest of the sedatives that he had and confirmed that the seal he had put on the Sun Brooch was effective, not allowing it to hurt them.

The carriage arrived at an old, abandoned dock, where Maric had some zombies buried, ready to be unleashed whenever he needed them. Sharron and Maric then left to lure in the enemies, while Klein set up the explosives they had prepared for him. He buried a small box in the middle of the open ground and left a paper figurine on a group of buried explosives before putting on the Sun Brooch and hiding on top of one of the warehouses, his face painted so he would be hard to recognize.

After checking on the bullets in his gun and everything else in his pockets, he used the figurine he had left to create an illusion of him hiding somewhere else, leaving the real him invisible. He slowly calmed his nerves before noticing a group of approaching figures.

Chapter 347: Zombie and Werewolf

(Note: Sharron and Maric will be referred to by name. If I say “Wraith”, “Zombie”, or “Werewolf”, then I’m referring to the enemies. A zombie without a capital “Z” means one controlled by a Beyonder, like Maric’s zombies)

The ones approaching were Maric, along with the Zombie and Werewolf who were chasing him. A hand rose from the soil to grab the Zombie’s ankle before more zombies were unearthed. They only briefly slowed him down, allowing the Werewolf to catch up to him. As the two taunted Maric, Sharron tried to possess the Zombie, making him attack his ally. The Werewolf quickly activated the Sealed Artifact in his possession, surrounding the area with the effect of a full moon.

Sharron was forced out of the Zombie as she became more corporeal and fell to the ground. She activated her own Sealed Artifact, which summoned a bronze door from which many arms and vines were extended. The vines grabbed the Zombie and tried to pull him in, and he could only slow them down, not fully stop them.

Meanwhile, Maric focused his attention on the Werewolf, and Klein took this opportunity to touch the black eye in his possession. Ignoring the ravings, he saw some threads not belonging to the ones he could see, they slowly approached Maric, and he realized that the Wraith planned to possess Maric.

Klein activated a group of explosives nearby, drawing everyone’s attention, then aimed his gun at the spot where the Wraith had been, using the Sun Brooch to imbue his bullet with the powers of purification.

Chapter 348: Terrifying Wraith

The bullet successfully hit the Wraith, but it brought his attention to Klein, and he immediately tried to possess him. Klein used the Sun Brooch to resist the possession before activating a Paper Figurine Substitute and teleporting through the flames left behind by the explosives he had activated. Ghosts were sent after him, clinging to his body, but he used the brooch to purify them.

In a desperate attempt to save the Zombie from the clutches of the bronze door, the Werewolf threw the Sealed Artifact towards him to strengthen him. Klein activated another explosive, with the shockwave sending the artifact off-course. Klein chased after it, but the Wraith got it first. The Wraith was in no hurry to deal with this "weak opponent", so he just disappeared, forcing Klein to use the black eye again to locate him.

Klein tried to shoot at the Zombie to attract the Wraith's attention, then activated another explosive, making him unable to hold any longer. The arms and vines successfully dragged the Zombie into the bronze door, and his screams could no longer be heard as it was sealed shut. The Wraith screeched, disrupting both ally and foe, and Maric was close to losing control of his zombies.

Chapter 349: Poison Bottle

Sharron made the bronze door disappear and Klein used the fire around them to teleport closer, but they both collapsed, along with Maric, as they felt ill; the Wraith had used another Sealed Artifact.

["Biological Poison Bottle can be used to randomly create different kinds of toxins. As long as you open it, the poisons will gradually spread to its surroundings.

"It will be effective in less than a minute, and the symptoms will only become worse. In four minutes, if you don't leave the poison-filled environment, then the corresponding effects will be unpreventable, such as death."]

The Biological Poison Bottle would usually have no effect on Spirit Bodies, but as Sharron was weakened by the effect of the full moon, she was unable to remain in her wraith-state, leaving her vulnerable to the effects of the poison. The Werewolf took advantage of their moment of weakness to attack Maric, while the Wraith kept talking as he waited for them to succumb to illness.

[*It seems like the poison has been weakened by the Sun Brooch's constant purification and purging effect...* Klein suddenly sneered.

"Are you planning on attacking us after we succumb to the poison? Why do you think I didn't use fireworks just now? Why do you think I relied on explosives? With so many explosions, I've definitely attracted the attention of others. The official Beyonders nearby are rushing here at this very moment. You don't have much time left!"]

The Wraith laughed at Klein, who used his gun to shoot, easily evading. However, Klein wasn't shooting at him, he aimed at the center of the clearing, where he had buried a small box earlier. Suddenly, all zombies and ghosts charged at the box, and the Wraith could no longer control them. Klein detonated more explosives and used the flames to continuously teleport, making the Wraith think that he was trying to escape.

The Wraith chose to chase after the zombies and ghosts to find out what had agitated them so much. He successfully took the small case from them; in it were a copper whistle and a bronze key, chained together. As the light of the full moon reached the key, the Wraith started hearing strange sounds ripping through his head. He dropped the whistle and the key, along with his Sealed Artifact that simulated a full moon.

Klein appeared, deflecting the Sealed Artifact toward the weakened Sharron. As she held it, she became immune to the effects of the full moon, and she regained her power, no longer being affected by the poison in the air. The zombies and ghosts kept fighting over the Master Key and Azik's Copper Whistle, and Klein took advantage of them being grouped together to purify them with the Sun Brooch.

Sharron made the bronze door appear once again, and the arms protruding from it grabbed the Wraith who was close to losing control. As he was being dragged, Klein alternated between using the Sun Brooch's purifying spells and shooting bullets imbued with its power, all aimed at the Wraith's head.

Chapter 350: Splendid Fireworks

Sharron failed to maintain the bronze door long enough for it to swallow the Wraith, but, as it disappeared, she possessed him to keep hitting himself where Klein had injured him. The now-headless Wraith tried to escape as she was forced out of his body, but Klein detonated the explosives beneath the Wraith's feet, which turned out to be fireworks that tore his body as they lit up the sky.

The Biological Poison Bottle fell to the ground and, as he watched the firework show before him, Klein felt his potion being digested a bit more. Taking off his hat, he pressed it to his chest as he bowed in Sharron's direction. Sharron's attention was on the Werewolf, and she focused on possessing him to pull off his own head before quickly making his Beyonder characteristic take shape.

Klein collected the bullet shells so any later investigations wouldn't lead to the person who sold them to him, and Sharron gave him the Biological Poison Bottle along with the Werewolf characteristic. He sealed them in a small box he had already prepared while Sharron collected the Wraith characteristic. She deactivated the full moon Sealed Artifact, and only then did Klein dare to collect the Master Key and Azik's Copper Whistle, sealing them in another small box. Sharron told him that the mysticism book was already in his room and asked if he needed any help cleaning up the scene.

["There's no need." Klein chuckled. "I still have lots of fireworks which I haven't released."

As soon as he finished his sentence, he raised his hand and snapped his fingers. The remaining explosives exploded, one by one, sending flames up into the sky. They clustered around the largest and most eye-catching one in the center, producing a dreamy and beautiful scene.

Sharron's gaze was instinctively attracted to it for a second, and when she looked back, Klein was no longer there. There was only a spark that gradually dissipated.]

Klein took a detour away from the dock, wiped the paint on his face, then straightened out his clothes as he walked out onto the streets like a normal person. He walked into a cathedral, hoping to avoid the inspection the official Beyonders would perform on the surrounding areas. It wasn't even 11 yet, so there were still a few others there.

Chapter 351: "Game" of Question and Answer

After returning home, Klein was in no hurry to study the book until the commotion subsided, especially because it might contain secrets that still too much for a Sequence 7 like him. Instead, he threw everything Beyonder-related above the gray fog and decided to rest.

In the clearing surrounded by abandoned warehouses, the Machinery Hivemind were investigating the scene. One of them held a silver mirror, and he spoke to it.

[“Honorable Arrodes, my question is ‘Who were the participants in the incident that just happened here?’”]

The mirror showed images of Klein, Sharron, Maric, and their enemies, but all of their faces were blurred out. It then showed the fireworks followed by Klein’s bow to his audience.

[…several lines of text in ancient Feysac appeared on the surface of the mirror.

“Based on the principle of reciprocity, it’s my turn to ask the question. If you answer wrong or lie, you will be punished.”

The word “punished” was blood-red, as if it were dripping with liquid!]
(It just likes to ask embarrassing questions)

Early the next morning, Klein headed above the gray fog. He started with the Werewolf characteristic, divining what it could do; he had a lot of information about the Sequence and its pathway, so the divination wouldn’t fail. He saw scenes that showcased the abilities of a Werewolf, along with a scene that showed this characteristic getting affected by the full moon. This meant that whoever would use it as the main ingredient for a potion would have to be careful not to lose control when advancing.

The Zombie Beyonder characteristic, however, was unfortunately swallowed by the bronze door Sharron had used, and Klein had no idea whether that was something he could ever get back.

As for the Biological Poison Bottle, Dream Divination showed many scenes, some that Klein couldn’t get exact interpretations for. All he knew for sure was that when the user removed the lid, poison would start spreading, with those affected getting infected by random illnesses. It also seemed like carrying it along for long periods of time could get him affected, even with the lid on.

He wanted to experiment, but he wasn’t sure it would work above the gray fog, and he only entered this place in his Spirit Body state, so he couldn’t get poisoned at all. Leaving it aside, he turned to the mysticism book Sharron had left him, titled “The Book of Secrets”.

[Flipping another page, Klein finally saw the opening line of the Book of Secrets: “We worship the moon, not the Evernight Goddess.”]

Chapter 352: Breakfast

This wasn’t the first time Klein had encountered such a belief, but his knowledge of history proved that the author of this book and the other groups he encountered had no way of coming into contact with each other. And, as there was no other moon deity known, Klein was led to speculate that there used to be some believers in the moon first, then Evernight stole some of its authority, but the belief continued to be passed down in multiple groups across the continents.

The book detailed many rituals and deeds directed at a primitive worship of the moon, with the Honorific Name “The one and only red moon, the symbol of life and beauty, the mother of all spiritual

forces.” This didn’t matter much to Klein, as he only wanted to learn the underlying rules to make his own rituals. He wasn’t planning on actually praying the Primordial Moon.

After returning to the real world, Klein found that he had seemingly caught a cold after carrying around the Biological Poison Bottle for a while as he stayed in the cathedral the previous night. He felt embarrassed at being a Sequence 7 Beyonder who fell ill, but he was thankful that it wasn’t too serious. He would have to be careful not to carry it around for too long, lest it actually infect him with something deadly. At 8 in the morning, Mike Joseph came by, and Klein accepted the job of being his bodyguard.

[Klein sized him up and said, “Sir, you’d better change into something a little worse; otherwise, there will be lots of work for me.”

Mike looked down at his tweed coat and said with some realization, “This is too eye-catching?”

“It is in East Borough.” Klein pointed into his place. “I have some specially prepared clothes. Hmm, we are about the same size.”

Mike couldn’t help but exclaim, “You really are a professional.”

Professional criminal? Klein lampooned.

After changing into ordinary worker’s clothes, the two boarded the carriage and headed for the outskirts of East Borough.]

As they entered a café for breakfast, Klein saw the man he had interviewed when pretending to be a reporter (refer to volume 2 part 2, chapter 282). The two joined him at his table, where he told Klein that, thanks to him, he was able to eat his fill and find a place to sleep. He was also attempting to get a new job. Mike listened to them and took some notes.

Chapter 353: Today Is Quite Different From Yesterday

Through the window, they noticed an old lady walking aimlessly around the street. Her clothes and hair looked neater than the others, and she persisted in not squeezing together with the group cowering on the ground.

[“She’s also a pitiful person.” The former tramp who had eaten the leftover black bread also noticed the old lady and sighed, “She was said to have led quite a good life in the past. Her husband was a grain merchant and had a very spirited child, but unfortunately, he went bankrupt and her husband and child died not long after. She’s different from us, really, and you can tell at a glance... Sigh, she won’t be able to hold on much longer, unless she’s lucky to be admitted into the workhouse every time.”

As he listened, Mike’s expression changed from quiet to somber. He slowly let out a sigh and said, “I want to interview her. Can you invite her for me? She can eat and drink whatever she wants here.”]

They asked her to order whatever she wanted in exchange for the interview, and she chose something small and simple. She told them about her husband’s business and how it failed, taking him along from her.

[“My child, a brilliant young man, had been learning the ropes of doing business from his father. He couldn’t suffer the blow, and he ended up jumping into the Tussock River on a moonless night. His first suicide didn’t work. He was sent to the magistrate’s court, and the police and judges were very impatient, feeling that he was wasting their time.

“If you want to commit suicide, please do so quietly and successfully. Don’t trouble us... Yes, that was probably what they wanted to say, but they found it too direct. My child was put in prison. Not long after, he committed suicide for the second time and succeeded.”

The old lady spoke very calmly, as though it wasn’t something that had happened to her. But for some reason, Klein felt a deep sense of sorrow.

Nothing is more lamentable than a dead heart... He suddenly recalled the saying he had heard in his previous life.]

After finishing her meal, the old woman asked if she could sleep for a bit, and Mike didn’t refuse her.

[Mike looked at the man beside him and said, “You seem to be very familiar with this place. I wish to hire you as our guide. How’s three soli for the day? I’m sorry, I forgot to ask for your name.”

The man quickly shook his head and said, “No, no, that is too much. I only earn one soli a day most of the time at the dock. Just call me Old Kohler.”

“Then, two soli a day. You deserve it,” Mike decided firmly.

After witnessing this strange bargaining, Klein blew into a piece of tissue and was about to drink another cup of coffee, when he suddenly sensed that something was wrong. He turned to look at the old lady who was curled up, asleep on the chair. Her face, which had turned ruddy due to the coffee, was pale again. The colors of her aura and moods had vanished.

“...” Klein stood up and subconsciously extended his hand to check the old lady’s breathing.

As Mike and Kohler looked at him in surprise, he said heavily, “She’s dead.”]

The lack of reaction from Kohler and the people in the café showed how common of an occurrence this was in East Borough, they just called the police. The officer asked about their identities and inspected Klein for any illegal weapons but found none, so he just got someone to take away the old woman’s corpse.

[Mike clenched his fist and pounded on the table. “A living person just died here; yet, all he cares about is investigating the unlawful possession of firearms!?” Upon saying this, Mike looked at Klein and asked, puzzled, “You didn’t bring a gun?”

Klein shook his head, pulled out his holster and revolver from under the table, and said calmly, “As a detective, I have a lot of experience in this area.”

As a Magician, he could place the revolver right in front of someone and make it impossible for the person to notice it. Moreover, since he didn’t buy any ordinary bullets, the Beyonder bullets were temporarily left above the gray fog. His revolver was currently empty, but this didn’t stop him from shooting with his revolver. All he needed to do was to use his mouth to emulate a “bang” when he pulled the trigger.]

Klein and Mike decided to do the interviews by visiting apartments where multiple people lived together, along with those they would encounter on their way in the streets. Kohler, who couldn't read so had no idea what the papers in Mike's hand said, just agreed with whatever Klein suggested.

Chapter 354: Tales of an "Adventure" in East Borough

They encountered a group of children, with Kohler informing the other two that they were trained thieves. He also told them that the youngest thief that was ever caught was only six years old. Kohler then helped them avoid a street that was controlled by a gang.

["Mr. Reporter, have you heard of them?" Old Kohler asked in surprise.

Mike sneered. "They're involved in a lot of cases, and they have some reputation outside East Borough as well. It's said that one of the members was involved in a case of Intis espionage."

...The person next to you was the person in question, the person who made the report, and also the victim... Klein silently added.]

They entered a district with relatively better buildings and passed by many street vendors. This reminded Klein of his life back in Tingen before his Nighthawk salary allowed him to move his siblings out to a better area. They passed by a watch repair shop, and Klein continued to reminisce.

[Back then, Benson, Melissa, and himself had gone to somewhere similar to repair the silver pocket watch which his father had left behind, but despite repairing it several times, it would quickly break. This continued until Melissa fiddled with it and ultimately fully repaired it. It became the most decent thing on Klein's person during that period of time.

After Klein's "death", the pocket watch, which had both monetary and sentimental value, was not buried with him.

It should now belong to Benson, right? I wonder if he will think of me every time he takes out that pocket watch... Klein suddenly blinked and curled the corner of his lips.]

They walked in and met the craftsman, with Mike pretending like his pocket watch needed to be fixed.

[He pointed at a chair beside the table and said, "Please wait a moment. I'll go get my tools."

"Your tools are not at home?" Mike asked in surprise.

The watch craftsman shook his head and laughed. "How is that possible?

"A set of tools is very expensive. There's no way I can buy them on my own. The only way is to pool everyone's money together to buy three or four sets, and whoever has business will use them. So, we moved in together. Heh heh, it's more convenient this way. If we live too far away, we will have to spend extra time and pay for the public carriage to borrow the tools."]

After talking to the craftsman and a few others for a while, the trio left the apartment that served as a shop.

[They had walked about a hundred meters when they heard people quarreling along the street. The two women were using all sorts of obscenities against each other, allowing Klein to learn many words he had never heard before.]

Kohler took them to the apartment where the two women lived; one of them worked as a laundry maid along with her two daughters. Inside, they found a girl around 17 or 18 scrubbing some clothes, while her younger sister was carefully ironing others, having clearly been scalded before. Mike tried to interview them, but the eldest refused, saying that they had a lot of work to do and couldn't afford to waste time, sending them on their way.

[City of Silver. After a thorough examination of Derrick Berg, who had experienced hallucinations both visually and auditory, he was brought to the bottom of the spire. This place took in residents who showed signs of losing control, and various methods were used to save them.

Walking in the gloomy and creepy corridor, he suddenly felt a strange chill.

"Help!" A sharp shrill voice suddenly sounded from a sealed room.

"Help..." The voice came to a sudden halt, and then there was silence.]

Chapter 355: Outsider

["Someone is calling out for help," the young Derrick informed the two Dawn Paladins.

On his left, a tall knight clad in silver armor calmly replied, "Don't be fooled. That's just the normal behavior of those Beyonders who are on the verge of losing control."

Is that so? Maybe he cried out for help because he just isn't willing to give up and lose control and become a monster... Derrick thought sorrowfully.]

The guards gave him a medicine that calmed the voices in his head before locking him in his cell, which had many drawings on the walls that seemed to form a seal. Derrick suddenly heard banging on the wall from a cell next to him. Then a blinding light appeared and, when it was gone, the banging had stopped.

Knocking came from the cell on his other side, and the old man in it explained that Derrick's other neighbor must have completely lost control and was finished off by the seals surrounding them. The man also said that he had been trapped there for 42 years, as he was believed to be rather dangerous, even though he had shown no sign of losing control.

[The elderly voice was silent for a moment before saying, "I was once the captain of an exploratory team. We found a destroyed city about half a month away from the City of Silver. Heh, this was calculated based on our speed.

"That city was similar to our City of Silver. It clearly has traces of it being ruled by giants, and it also believed in the Lord that created everything, the omnipotent and omniscient God. Unfortunately, they were destroyed; destroyed countless years ago."]

[“However, we met a person there. This is the first time in the past 2000 years that our City of Silver had met someone who didn’t belong to our city! Outside City of Silver, in the depths of the endless darkness, there really was someone still alive!”]

[Without waiting for Derrick to speak, he sighed and said to himself, “We very warily invited that person to the City of Silver as a guest. After some consideration, he agreed. We monitored and escorted him along the way back, but when we had almost arrived at the City of Silver, he suddenly disappeared... We searched everywhere, but we couldn’t find him. After we returned to the City of Silver, my team members went crazy, one by one. They lost control. All of them! Not a single one was spared!

“The six-member council suspected that we were contaminated by something and that the person was not a human at all, but an evil spirit, a monster. So, they locked me up here, and every so often, they would come over to confirm my condition, but they would never tell me what the problem is, nor would they let me out.”]

[Derrick pressed him, casually, “Did he say what his name was? Did he tell you about his origins?”

The elderly voice acknowledged tersely. “He told us that his name was...” He paused for a moment before saying, “Amon.”]

Chapter 356: Informant Fee

The trio in East Borough arrived at the factory district; the place most affected by the smog that enveloped all of Backlund. Old Kohler merely cleared his throat, Mike kept coughing, and Klein couldn’t even smell anything in the first place. They were surprised at the workers not even wearing masks or any form of protection while walking among what looked like toxic gas.

[He seemed to have already witnessed the future of each and every female worker—some of them with throbbing heads, some with blurred vision, some turning hysterical, some with gums with a blue line, and finally, they either went blind or fell dead.

It’s like a large-scale, bloody sacrificial ritual. The only difference is that the target is that flashing symbol of money...]

Mike, Klein, and Kohler didn’t spend long trying to interview the workers. On their way out of the district, they encountered a group of people protesting around a few factories, and they learned that those were workers who wanted to smash the new machines that would replace them and leave them without work. The trio couldn’t do much to help, so they left.

As Mike took a carriage away, Klein took this chance to ask Kohler to watch over the state of the East Borough for him, and he would pay him, of course. They would meet up once a week; Klein was worried about the state of this place and how it could be perfect for the descent of an evil deity, like what was happening in Tingen.

Elsewhere, Audrey had started her lessons with Escalante, who started to drop hints about mysticism and organizations. Audrey kept Susie by her side through the whole thing.

[Then, she tilted her head and said, “However, what she said is very interesting. I think it’s even more interesting than meat and biscuits!”

Susie, do you wish to be a psychiatrist in the future? Specializing in the treatment of mental illness in animals? For example, that horse which is suspected to suffer from depression at the Glaints... Audrey suddenly fell into deep thought, wondering if she should prepare a special white coat and gold-rimmed glasses for Susie to look a little more professional.]

Chapter 357: Happenings at the Banquet

At Klein’s home, he got ready before heading to the Sammers’ for the party he was invited to (refer to chapter 240).

[Stelyn played her role as the female host to its fullest. “Have your meal first. I’ll introduce you to a few well-educated ladies later.”

Actually, there’s no need for that. Just let me eat in peace... Klein smiled.]

[Klein, with his large plate, didn’t make conversation with anyone. He hid in a corner and slowly savored the food.]

Jurgen Cooper joined Klein in his little corner, and Klein asked about his grandmother, learning that she was to be discharged the following week. Stelyn Sammer found them, bent on introducing them to her other guests, she even included the two men’s income in her introductions. Noticing that most of the attention was on Jurgen, Klein wanted to take the chance to escape the group.

[After a short casual chat with them, he found an excuse to leave before hiding in a corner and eating while he enjoyed watching Jurgen’s awkward and helpless performance. At this moment, it was a wonder where his eloquence as a lawyer had gone to.]

He was found by the Sammers’ children, who had heard that he was a detective and were very eager to hear about the cases he had cracked.

[*The cases I cracked? If it doesn’t involve wraiths, puppets, or Devil dogs, then it’s about finding cats or catching an adulterer. There’s really nothing suitable for children...* Klein thought for a few seconds, then chuckled.]

In the end, he made up some stories to tell them, mixing them with stories he had read back on earth. Later, Stelyn told Klein that she and her husband were invited by Mary to a luncheon the following Monday hosted by the chief secretary of the National Atmospheric Pollution Council, Hibbert Hall (he is Audrey’s older brother, but Klein doesn’t know that, only us the readers do).

At that luncheon, Stelyn, who had been confident that her life wasn’t too different from the nobles, encountered Audrey and Susie. Believing that owning a dog would make her more like the girl before her, Stelyn asked how much one of these dogs would cost, only to learn that it was more than her husband’s annual income.

Chapter 358: The Sun's Worry

At 3 PM exactly, the Tarot gathering began. The Sun reported what had happened, and that he was isolated in a cell under the effect of one of the City of Silver's mystical items.

[Finally, he asked, "Honorable Mr. Fool, will that mystical item detect my participation in the Tarot Club?"

How would I know... I don't even know what it is... However, there are currently no strange or powerful forces attempting to invade...]

Seeing as The Fool only gave a vague answer, Derrick switched to asking if any of the other members knew of a person named Amon. Alger answered that there was a family with such a surname back in the Fourth Epoch, but speaking their name was taboo even in an era with numerous High-Sequence Beyonders.

Chapter 359: The Blasphemer

[The Hanged Man, Alger, didn't answer her directly as he continued on, "Abraham, Antigonus, Amon, Jacob, and Tamara are the five great families that supported the establishment of the Tudor Dynasty, and they were second only to the Blood Emperor.

"Among them, the Amon family is the most mysterious one. They have the least history left behind, and they seem to have been distorted and covered up by some kind of power. There was a piece of information that came from the King of the Five Seas, Nast. The Amons are a family of blasphemers, and they wield the secrets to usurp the powers of deities! Also, the Amon family call themselves the descendants of the ancient Sun God."]

Alger asked Derrick to try probing the man in the neighboring cell for information about Amon's goal, but to remain vigilant, as he could be very dangerous. Once that topic was over, Justice requested private audience with The Fool so she could give him 3 pages of Roselle's diary that she had acquired after another visit to the museum in an effort to appear normal and unrelated to the theft of the bookmarks.

[She had seen Fors and Xio once midweek, and by leading the conversation, she had naturally mentioned how her beloved dog, Susie, had chewed the Roselle notebook, causing it to be irrecoverable.

Typically speaking, she no longer needed to hide the fact that Mr. Fool needed Roselle's diary, but using her Telepathist abilities, she simulated what Fors would think, believing that she would have such a thought.

"What? That's a diary? That's a diary Roselle recorded his secrets in? Even Mr. Fool places so much importance on it! Eh, I recall that Miss Audrey has some. Wait a moment. She happened to have those diary pages chewed up by her dog a few days ago. Isn't this too much of a coincidence?"

To prevent Fors from having such thoughts, Audrey hoped to keep it a secret for at least another week.]

In exchange for the pages, The Fool informed her of the existence of a Sequence 0, and that this card contained Sequence 0 Black Emperor.

The first diary entry was from Roselle's first week in this world. He wrote his old name, Huang Tao, and mentioned a "mysterious silver plate with some strange symbols and patterns engraved on it", suspecting it to be the reason for his transmigration. He also wrote about many things he would miss, like his parents, along with some novels he was reading or games he was playing.

The things he mentioned meant that him and Klein transmigrated within the same year, yet why did they appear in this world nearly 200 years apart?

Chapter 360: A Difficult Conundrum

[*That is to say, even if I were to spend two hundred years to find a way to return, it's likely that I won't lose the opportunity to meet my parents. At most, I'd have been missing for a year...* Klein made a contrasting inference, improving his mood significantly. He instantly felt filled with motivation. Of course, he himself knew very well that this reasoning was not rigorous, because this was determined by one precondition, and it was currently impossible to confirm it.

What if Roselle transmigrated after me? That might involve so-called spatial-temporal turbulence. When the time comes, there is no guarantee that I'll return to the proper time node... Klein poured cold water on his burgeoning mood.]

In a following entry, Roselle ran into a Beyonder fighting what seemed to be a monster or someone who lost control (this is an inference from his descriptions, he didn't know what those were when he wrote that), and he was determined to become like that person with the fantasy powers. He believed himself to be the protagonist of this world.

[*Indeed the protagonist? Emperor, did you pour all of your eighth-grader syndrome soul into your diary?* Klein couldn't help but lampoon.]

[He was very interested in the silver plate, which might have been the cause for Roselle's transmigration, and he was eager to find out what the symbols and patterns on it looked like.

If he could really decipher it by relying on the mysticism knowledge of this world, then transmigration might not have just been a coincidence...]

The trade section of the gathering just consisted of The Magician and The World asking the others to keep an eye out for the ingredients they needed to advance to Trickmaster and Faceless, respectively, while The Hanged Man gave them the description of a person he was looking for named Baelen, who was involved in the slave trade case he had mentioned the previous week.

After returning to the real world, Derrick knocked on the wall separating his cell from the one next to it, hoping to communicate with the other person as The Hanged Man had suggested.

[At this moment, an elderly and fleeting voice came from the bed behind him, "Are you looking for me..."]

Chapter 361: Translucent Worm

[*Why is he behind me? Why is he in my room? What happened to the seal? What about the effects of the mystical items?*]

Derrick slowly turned around, only to be faced with a horrifying monster. He immediately used his powers to purify it, but his abilities were out of control, much more powerful than they should have been.

[Just as it was about to become transparent, a phantom wearing a black classical long robe and a pointed hat suddenly appeared! The shadow had black hair, black eyes, a wide forehead, and a thin face. It wore a monocle carved from crystal.]

Light blinded Derrick, and when it was gone, he found himself in the corridor outside his cell. As he looked into it, he saw the Chief of the City of Silver's council, Colin Iliad. The man was brandishing his sword, and in the monster's place was a translucent worm.

[Colin nodded slightly and said, "We always knew that he had a problem, but in order to find out what kind of ulterior motives the man named Amon had, we intentionally didn't eliminate him directly, and we instead locked him at the bottom of the spire, sealed under the influence of mystical items, and we often let Beyonders, who only have symptoms of losing control, live next to him and talk to him. We wanted to see if we could induce some abnormal changes in him in order to learn the information we wanted to know.

"Unfortunately, he had been very normal until today, way too normal. Why do you think he suddenly mutated and attempted to break through the seal? Do you have any idea what makes you different from the others?"]

Derrick's only guess was his pathway, as he was the only Beyonder of the Sun pathway in the City of Silver. Colin then asked what he had been doing when his neighbor mutated.

[*I didn't do anything. I just knocked on the wall and tried to talk to him... Before this, before this, I was participating in the Tarot Gathering... The Tarot Gathering!* Derrick was suddenly stunned. He felt that things might not be as simple as he had imagined.

He knew that he couldn't inform the Chief of his thoughts, but he didn't know what kind of expression to make, so he could only maintain his lonely, reserved silence. He said thoughtfully, "I knocked on that wall three times. Before that, the candle in my room had extinguished, and there was complete darkness. I had tried to practice some of my Beyonder powers."]

After making sure that Derrick's state was stable, Colin sent the boy home. Once there, Derrick prayed to The Fool, informing him of everything that had just happened.

[And with his tense state of mind relaxing, he felt immense exhaustion wash through him. He lied down and quickly fell asleep. In the silent and dark room, flashes of lightning would occasionally illuminate everything. Otherwise, it would seem like the dark night.

The sleeping Derrick suddenly flicked his right index finger and leisurely tapped it on the bed.

Once, twice, thrice...]

Chapter 362: The Secret Deed Ritual

Klein, who had returned to the real world, took four steps counterclockwise and listened to The Sun's prayer.

[*The Sun believes that it's impossible that there was no reason for the man's loss of control. He came up with two possibilities—one was that his own Beyonder pathway met the requirements of being the ancient Sun God's descendant, and the other possibility was that the man might have sensed the Tarot Gathering and Mr. Fool's secret pull.*

If it were the former, he wouldn't have waited until today and waited until the end of the Tarot Gathering before losing control... The latter reason has a greater probability... Hmm, this is the first time I've encountered someone who can sense the matters regarding the gray fog... That Amon is very scary!]

[In the midst of his thoughts, Klein's eyes suddenly froze as he looked at the prayer scene.

Entwined on the indistinct body of The Sun was a translucent and illusory figure! He had hands and feet, but he was like a python, twisting around The Sun while his head rested behind The Sun's head! In the blurred image, he was wearing a black classical robe, a pointed hat, and a crystal monocle.

The Sun didn't notice any of this!]

[He vaguely understood the other party's intention. By residing in the Spirit Body of The Sun, he is waiting for the next Tarot Gathering, allowing him to sneak above the gray fog, like a virus or a Trojan horse!

When that happens, my control over this mysterious space might be snatched away... He's truly a Blasphemer! Fortunately, Little Sun is rather naive and straightforward, so he immediately reported this to me. Through the corresponding crimson stars and the power of the gray fog, I was able to discover his peculiar state... Klein drew a breath and tried to calm himself.]

[*Amon's Sequence is definitely above Sequence 4, and the means available to him must be sufficiently strange. To be able to escape from the City of Silver's mystical artifacts and powerful Demon Hunters, it means that he isn't something which can be easily eliminated with ordinary objects or powers!*

After thinking for a moment and looking around, Klein discovered there was only one possibility of eliminating Amon—the gray fog, this mysterious space.]

As Klein flipped through the Book of Secrets, he found something called a secret deed ritual, whose description and purpose were vague enough that it would allow him to modify it. Using his Honorific Name along with the symbol of The Fool behind his chair, he designed a ritual that should point to himself, before sending it to Little Sun to try it. He hoped this would allow him to manipulate the gray fog to expel Amon from The Sun's body by connecting Derrick's Soul Body to this mysterious space.

The Sun, who was woken up by Klein's contact with him, didn't hesitate to gather the necessary materials to perform the ritual. As Derrick connected to the gray fog, Klein noticed that Amon had sensed him, but he didn't know what to do next. As Klein thought about how to exorcise him, his attention turned to the Sun Brooch.

Chapter 363: High-level Authority

As Klein merged the power of the gray fog with the Sun Brooch, a golden figure took shape before him, ready to be sent through the ritual. However, Klein could sense that this wouldn't be strong enough, he needed something more "high level". The "highest level" item he currently possessed was the Black Emperor card.

As Klein was thinking, Amon reached into the gray fog, attempting to use the connection formed by the secret deed ritual to penetrate this space. With no time to hesitate, Klein held the card in his hand, and the golden figure grew twelve pairs of black wings. It merged with the figure of The Sun, forcing Amon to retreat. As the gray fog stabilized, Klein could see that Amon was gone, no longer clinging onto The Sun.

[*Is this the secret deed ritual as referenced in textbooks? For more than two thousand years, no one in the City of Silver has succeeded before. No one has been able to come into contact with a mighty existence...* At that moment, Derrick's low spirits and loneliness lessened. A heartfelt smile beamed on his face.

The Fool's so-called experiment was to confirm whether our City of Silver's environment can perform a secret deed ritual? That wondrous feeling of all that knowledge was the payment "He" gave me? Derrick lowered his head again and said with great respect, "Thank you, Mr. Fool!"]

[Then, Derrick saw himself covered in a transparent, illusory shadow. The figure wore a black classic robe, a matching pointed hat, and a crystal monocle hung from its face. It coiled around his body like a python!

This... Amon wasn't dead! He evaded the detection of the mystical items and the attention of His Excellency, and he became a parasite on my Spirit Body! Derrick's eyes widened, and he saw himself as he was now, no longer entangled by Amon.

Did Mr. Fool notice him and finish him? Derrick's sunken heart calmed down…]

Somewhere in the deep dark of the Forsaken Land, a man wearing a pointed hat and a monocle stood at an edge overlooking a grayish-white building at the bottom of a ravine.

["As expected..." he suddenly whispered, in the language of ancient Feysac.

After pausing for a moment, the man smiled and said the words, "The Fool."]

Chapter 364: Cathedral of Serenity

In Colin Iliad's office, a shadow appeared to report the results of his observations of Derrick. He mentioned how the boy seemed to be muttering something unintelligible to himself, before going to sleep briefly then waking up to perform a secret deed ritual. He no longer showed signs of abnormality after the ritual, and the two suspected that he was being controlled by Amon. As they believed Amon to be too strong for them to deal with, they settled on continued observation for the time being.

At Derrick's house, he suddenly started violently coughing until something came out; it was a translucent worm similar to the one he had seen in his cell after the Chief had killed the monster, but it seemed to be dead.

In the Loen Kingdom, there stood a large, black cathedral: it was the church of Evernight's headquarters, known as the Cathedral of Serenity. In it, Leonard Mitchell had just recently advanced and stabilized his condition.

[After going around a corner, Leonard saw a staircase leading down. There, he saw Captain Dunn Smith, with a pair of dark gray eyes and dressed in a black trench coat, and Klein Moretti, who exuded a bookish demeanor standing there, smiling and waiting.

He tilted his head back and sighed. *My memory has also gotten worse. I've already forgotten that the two of you no longer exist...*]

He met up with the other Red Gloves (an elite and special group among the Nighthawks); Crestet Cesimir was giving them a lecture about High-Sequence Beyonder abilities they needed to watch out for. Cesimir talked about High-Sequence Beyonders pretending to be hidden existences or being sealed in mystical items, and how they could try to extort regular Beyonders with promises to fulfill their wishes.

["The third case is for a High-Sequence potion named 'Parasite.' They often claim that they have lost their bodies and can only survive together with your Spirit Body. They can only rely on you and will not harm you. They will then give you knowledge, formulas, and all sorts of benefits, hoping that you can become powerful so that you can one day help him reconstruct his body or take revenge.

"In reality, the Beyonders with Parasites will only become nutrients for the Parasite; thus prolonging the Parasite's lifespan and condition."

As Leonard listened, his smile faded.]

Chapter 365: Vampire with A Unique Hobby

After the lecture, Leonard returned to his room.

[After ten seconds of silence, he said softly, almost gritting his teeth, "So you're a Parasite!"]

[In the blink of an eye, a slightly-aged voice resounded in his mind. *"You can say that."*

"What exactly do you want? Are you a being that's leeching my life through your parasitic means? Or are you waiting for me to become stronger, so you can directly devour my Beyonder characteristic, just like cultivating a humanoid potion?" Leonard's voice was suppressed, but in no way slow.]

[*"Would I not know that the Church of Evernight knows of Parasites? Would I not realize that the Red Gloves would grasp certain secrets to prevent the infiltration of High-Sequence Beyonders? But did I ever stop you from joining the Red Gloves?"*]

[*"Do you feel like you have aged faster than your real age? No, right? I can live for at least another hundred years. I'm not in a hurry to take over my host's life.*

“As for your Beyonder characteristics, humph. We aren’t even in a similar pathway that allows exchanging. If I swallow it, it would be equivalent to drinking poison, making me half-crazy and increasing my chance of losing control. Do you think that I would do that?

“Evernight is grouped with Giant and Death, while my Beyonder pathway’s goal is that of the Apprentice and Seer.”]

[Leonard looked at his body which was illuminated by the crimson moonlight. After some thought, he asked again, “What exactly do you want to do? What is your purpose?”

The slightly-aged voice in his mind sighed. “Didn’t I already tell you? I’ve suffered tremendous damage, and I need a host to recover slowly, and I have to hide from a terrible enemy... The Nighthawks, the Church of Evernight, is quite a good choice for a host.”]

[Leonard listened with a serious expression. After a while, he said, “You have a terrifying enemy? Who is he?”

The slightly-aged voice chuckled and said, *“I don’t know his name, but I do know his last name...”*

“What is it?” Leonard asked.

The slightly-aged voice suddenly became low and deep. *“Amon.”*]

Elsewhere in Backlund, Klein, disguised as a police officer with the aid of an illusion, visited the address he had heard from the vampire Emlyn White to determine whether he should help them as a way to act and digest his potion. For that, he had to determine whether Emlyn and his companions were law-abiding monsters.

[*Yes, law-abiding monsters! Although this doesn’t sound right and sounds a little funny, it’s how I would react with my true thoughts...* Klein emphasized in his heart.]

As he was sure they would have moved away as soon as they knew Emlyn was captured, he decided to gather information by asking the neighbors about them, saying that they were involved in a case.

[“It’s no wonder they moved away so hurriedly more than a month ago... Most of the residents of Riverbay Avenue and the neighborhood knew the Whites and their son. He was a handsome but eccentric young man. Mr. White is an excellent physician and is good at using all kinds of medicine and bloodletting therapy.”

“Bloodletting therapy?” Klein returned with a question.

“Yes, although this has been regarded by many newspapers and magazines as an old medical skill that had no effect, anyone who received Mr. White’s treatment were cured. However, Mr. White also said that except for him, the other doctors who practice bloodletting therapy are quacks.”]

[One family at a time, he knocked on the door, asked questions, compiled answers, and came to the conclusion that the White family was indeed kind, amiable, and law-abiding.]

When he was done, Klein snuck into their now-abandoned home, hoping to do a divination to find more clues about them using the things they left behind in their haste. Everything was in disarray, with even

books about herbs and remedies being abandoned. One of the rooms, however, was filled with dolls of all shapes and sizes.

[Klein looked around and couldn't help but exclaim, "These dolls are not cheap! Don't tell me Emlyn is a vampire who is obsessed with dolls?"]

Chapter 366: The Hanged Man's Ambition

Heading above the gray fog, Klein used divination to make sure that these were just ordinary dolls, then he checked whether there had been any deaths in the Whites' home just in case they were only acting nice. He found nothing suspicious, not even after sneaking into the nearest police station for their records on the people of the area.

After returning home, Klein got a map of Backlund and started to study the area around the Harvest church to familiarize himself with the area for his rescue plan. He then wrote a letter to Stuart to lead him to look for Emlyn in a different area.

In the vast sea, Alger had finally digested his Seafarer potion.

[After obtaining the potion formula for the Wind-blessed and finding the corresponding Beyonder ingredients, he would hide his advancement to Sequence 6 from the Church. Then, he would repeat the same process again, striving to become a Sequence 5 Ocean Songster within three years.]

[*Once I'm promoted to Sequence 5 and gain sufficient strength, I'll be able to secretly return to that place...* Alger subconsciously looked to his right. His gaze seemed to pierce through the planks of the ship and the vast sea, and onto an ancient and hidden island.

Alger wasn't worried about his future advancement within the Church. Once he fulfilled his wishes, he would be able to fully focus on seeking a higher position in the Church! At that time, he would continue to disguise himself as a Sequence 7 despite being a Sequence 5 and drink another Wind-blessed potion! This would increase his Beyonder characteristics, strengthen him, and slow his digestion, but it wouldn't endanger his own safety.]

Back at Klein's home, just as he was about to get some sleep, he noticed an abnormality in his own actions; he had been delaying the divinations he had wanted to perform on the Werewolf characteristic and the Biological Poison Bottle. The last time something like this had happened was he kept accidentally missing his chance to use his Spirit Vision on Megose, which ended up being due to her carrying the True Creator's spawn, making it dangerous for him to look.

Did one of those two items harbor such danger? He would have to attempt divination the following day and see if his spiritual intuition would stop or warn him.

Chapter 367: Threatening Letter

The next morning, Klein was on his way to post the letter he had written for Stuart when he encountered Mrs. Doris, Jurgen Cooper's grandmother. They conversed briefly before he continued on his way.

[He had just activated his Spirit Vision to look at Mrs. Doris's aura and found that her situation wasn't too good. It wasn't only because of her old age but also because of the cold weather and bad air in Backlund. All of these had a very bad effect on her lung disease.

Mrs. Doris should be able to make it through this late autumn and winter, but it will be hard to say for the next one, or the next, next one... If she wants to live for a few more years, she would have to move to the south, to the area around Desi Bay... It's a pity that it's likely that Lawyer Jurgen can't afford to do so now... Even I haven't been to Desi Bay... Klein mumbled, came to the mailbox, and stuffed the letter in.]

He bought himself some breakfast before heading back home, finding Stelyn Sammer and Madam Mary waiting for him, looking anxious. He invited them in to talk in more detail.

[As he spoke, he glanced at his landlady, Stelyn, and he noticed that her condition was entirely different from the past two days. She had become very low and dejected, as though she wasn't interested in anything at all.

What happened to her? Although his landlady liked to show off a little, she's someone who loves life a lot... Klein took out his key and opened the door.]

[After entering, before she could sit still, Ma'am Mary impatiently said, "Detective Moriarty, I received a threatening letter!"

Threatening letter? Klein put down the Desi pie, clasped his hands and asked, "What does the letter say?"

Ma'am Mary glanced sideways at Mrs. Stelyn, and seeing that she wasn't quite as active as usual, she said after some deliberation, "That letter asked me to handle the smoke of the factory impartially when I carry out the atmospheric pollution investigation and to acknowledge their contributions, or else I would end up like the doll that came with the letter...The doll's head was ripped off, and its arms and legs were broken."]

Klein advised her to report it to the police, knowing that a threat to a political figure would reach the Nighthawks. She said that she already did. This left Klein feeling suspicious, as the sender would have either been caught already, or they had some way to circumvent divination, which would make the situation even more complicated.

As she asked him for help, citing everyone else's praise for his work, Klein flicked a coin in his hand, divining whether this matter held any danger. He was surprised to see that the answer was "no"; that would only happen if this was just a threat with no actual action plan, or if this was a trap that aimed at pushing a political agenda.

He told Mary to go home in peace; if someone came to her to discuss making this issue public within the next few days, that would mean that she was safe and everything was fine. Otherwise, he would provide her protection.

Not long after Mary returned home, she received a visitor; Hibbert Hall. He offered some words of concern for her before discussing bringing a reporter to write about her experience and make it known to the public, exactly as Detective Moriarty had predicted. As for Klein, he rested for a while before heading above the gray fog; he wouldn't delay his divinations any longer.

Chapter 368: Taking Him by Surprise

At the head of the table sat Klein, staring at the Biological Poison Bottle for a bit before divining its origins. He saw the scene of a man wearing a white coat surrounded by many poisonous animals and plants. The man kept adding some of them as ingredients into a pot, and when nothing happened, added some drops of his own blood. Suddenly, the pot started absorbing everything around it, including the man himself, until all that was left was the small bottle that was now the Sealed Artifact.

This scene meant that the Biological Poison Bottle wasn't created from a Beyonder characteristic, and in turn could not be used to divine a potion formula or extract a characteristic that could be sold. But, seeing as it wasn't the risk Klein had been fearing, he decided to abandon his curiosity about the Werewolf characteristic.

In the Hall villa, Audrey had another psychology lesson with Escalante. The woman told her about a theory in psychology that described each person's consciousness as an island, with all island's being connected by one ocean. This meant that sometimes things from an individual's mind could leak into the collective subconscious, affecting the thoughts of others, mostly those closer to them, as venturing too deep into the ocean could lead to a loss of oneself.

When Escalante left, Audrey reached the conclusion that she was at most a Sequence 8 Telepathist like herself, and that what she just taught her was probably the axiom of the Psychology Alchemists.

[As Audrey was in thought, Susie commented happily from the side, "Audrey, I feel like she's the same type of person as us. No, I mean the same type of dog. No, that's not right... Woof!"

Susie, who only had a rudimentary grasp of the human language, fell into a state of confusion, unable to find the right words to describe her feelings.]

At the Harvest church, Klein wanted to confirm the situation first before attempting to rescue Emlyn, return him to his family, and gain the applause of the audience. However, he was surprised to find Emlyn wearing priest robes and doing simple work around the church. Klein stopped Emlyn and told him that his friend was entrusted with finding him, but Emlyn just shrugged off his concerns.

[This answer was completely out of Klein's expectations. For a moment, he didn't know how to respond, and he could only shout repeatedly in his mind: *Hey, you were very adamant about your worship of the moon the last time we interacted at the Harvest Church. You said that you would absolutely not convert to believing in Earth Mother. How long has it been, and you have already given in?*

Isn't that way too fast? What about your persistence? Where's your moral integrity? My carefully prepared performance has been forced to end before it has even begun. Th-this is just taking me by surprise!

Klein opened his mouth and suddenly realized something amiss. *Why is Emlyn White informing me of his conversion? I'm just a detective who accidentally chanced upon him while passing by... Does he wish for me to pass this message to his parents? Is there another meaning behind this?*

While Klein was guessing, Emlyn White put away his worried and smiled smugly. “You don’t have to act, Mister Detective. Or should I call you the new owner of the Master Key? Hehe, to a noble Sanguine, everyone has a different smell and has different blood characteristics. Even when I was locked up in the basement, I could smell it. I remember your smell.”]

Chapter 369: Inception

Klein was worried that him being a Beyonder was exposed. But multiple things calmed him: first, during the ambassador incident, he made contact with a Beyonder circle, making it possible for him to “become” one too, with no need to look into his past. Second, detective Isengard Stanton was likely a Beyonder, and he had good relations with the police while also suspecting Klein of being a Beyonder too, so he could be considered a pseudo-official Beyonder. Third, even if anything went wrong, he could easily abandon his identity as Sherlock Moriarty along with his current home. Fourth, he had already done some divinations before coming here, so he knew there was almost no danger.

[The vampire looked at Bishop Utravsky, who was leading the believers in the rite of Holy Communion, and he said with a sneer, “Mister Detective, aren’t you afraid that I’ll go to the police station and shout out loud that you’re a Beyonder?”

Similarly, Klein looked forward and said without turning his head, “I’ll go with you and shout out loud that there’s a vampire!”

Come on, let’s have an internecine outcome! Do you think I’m afraid of you!?

Emlyn White’s expression stiffened, he raised his right index finger and said, “Sanguine, a noble Sanguine! Got it?”]

Emlyn told Klein that he had lied to Utravsky, telling him he would convert his faith, and Utravsky easily believed him and promised to let him go once he memorized some things. Klein immediately guessed that Utravsky had used the same Sealed Artifact that had allowed him to enter his mind to plant an idea in Emlyn’s mind so he wouldn’t want to leave. Emlyn kept trying to argue, probably more in an effort to convince himself more than Klein that this wasn’t true.

Once Emlyn learned from Klein that his parents abandoned everything in his room when they moved away, he suddenly became very eager to leave right that moment, so Klein found a chance to talk to Utravsky, who told him that Emlyn could return home whenever he wanted. The two rushed out of the cathedral.

[After proceeding forward in what appeared like a jog, Emlyn suddenly slowed down and said in a daze, “I feel like I’m starting to miss the Harvest Church, the feeling of memorizing the Holy Bible, and the Sacred Emblem of Life. I wish to return to clean and tidy the place. It’ll only take an hour, an hour...”

This planted seed is even more “vicious” than I had imagined. No matter where this vampire goes, he will return to the Harvest Church every day and work for an hour? That’s actually quite alright. At the very least, the seed, which was planted, didn’t change Emlyn’s faith. In a way, he’s showing him some respect, but why did I use the word ‘respect’... That candle is called Mental Terror Candle, and it’s said to be from a dragon. The Spectator pathway is rather scary...]

After Klein returned Emlyn to his abandoned home, he told him that his payment would be in the form of the bounty money his parents had been offering, along with making a medicine with Beyonder effects to help Klein treat a patient.

Chapter 370: The Audience's Applause

[This was not the answer that he had expected. *What about your gentlemanliness?* the vampire thought in shock.

As a detective, abiding by clear accounting principles is necessary. Besides, you've even delayed my visit to the Quelaag Club. I don't know what food they've offered in limited supply for the past two days... Klein looked at Emlyn White as he joked and lampooned silently.

After a few seconds, Emlyn forced a smile and said, "I have to see the patient before I can concoct the appropriate medicine."]

Klein agreed to take him when it was time, and promised to help him be on the lookout for ways to remove the effects of Utravsky's Sealed Artifact. As Klein's thoughts wandered, he felt that he had no need to nurture an Apothecary Beyonder anymore; he could just keep returning to the Harvest church if he needed medicine form Emlyn. He also remembered how the vampires were followers of the Primordial Moon, just like the author of the Book of Secrets, leading him to guess that the Primordial Moon was the Vampire Ancestor, Lilith, whom the Sun had talked about before. (Refer to volume 2 part 2, chapter 313)

As Klein returned home, he found a letter left to him by Jurgen Cooper thanking him for taking care of the cat while he was away, along with the payment they had agreed on. After that, he wrote a letter to detective Stuart, who had been commissioned to find Emlyn.

[After writing the beginning pleasantries, he wrote after some deliberation: "...I found Emlyn White at the Harvest Church near Tuteva Street. It's a very small cathedral belonging to the Church of Earth Mother. It isn't very common in Loen... Emlyn White claimed that it was because of certain matters that he chose to run away from home. Afterwards, he was taken in by the bishop of the Harvest Church and stayed there, becoming a..."

Klein thought for a moment before writing down the word "volunteer."

Then he added simply: "Thanks to my persuasion, he has returned to 48 Riverbay Avenue. However, he might visit the Harvest Church often for volunteer work."]

The next morning, after sending the letter he had written the day before, Klein contemplated how the Emlyn case failed to be a "performance" for his digestion, and any other things he encountered recently were either already handled by official Beyonders, or higher than him in Sequence, so there weren't other chances to perform as a Magician. He ended up remembering the incident with Amon and how important the ritual he had found was in solving it, so he chose to spend the day studying the Book of Secrets.

The bell rang at noon; detective Stuart had come to praise Klein for finding Emlyn. The performance, therefor, wasn't a total failure, it just had only one member in the audience.

Chapter 371: Detective Moriarty's First Fan

Klein invited him in, and Stuart started talking about his travel plans for new year's. Klein was left in a trance, remembering all the promises he had made to his siblings about taking them to travel, before he died. Stuart then gave Klein his share of the bounty money for finding Emlyn.

[Stuart didn't ask any further questions and instead said with a smile, "Apart from Mr. Stanton, you're the best detective I've ever met. Did you join this profession midway, or have you studied under a great detective prior to this?"

What great detective have I studied under? There's quite a number. There's Sherlock Holmes, Hercule Poirot, the forever elementary school student, and that guy who swindles others in the name of his grandfather... Klein silently lampooned.] (The last two are characters from Detective Conan and The Kindaichi Case Files, respectively)

The two conversed a bit more, with Stuart expressing his admiration for Klein whenever he could, before the detective left. Klein spent the rest of his day studying the Book of Secrets before the doorbell rang again around dinnertime, with Emlyn being the one paying him a visit. Klein teased him a bit for having still gone back to the Harvest church, then the two were on their way to visit the patient Klein had mentioned before; Mrs. Doris, Jurgen Cooper's grandmother.

[Looking at the wet ground in front of him, Emlyn casually said, "Do you know what I like most about Backlund?"

"What?" Klein responded without any curiosity.

Emlyn chuckled and said, "The persistent gloomy sky with fog that blots out the sun. This allows me to go out during the day without feeling too much discomfort. It's great, except for the air."

In other words, the sun really would deal certain damage to vampires? Fortunately, I thought of this yesterday and didn't bring the Sun Brooch with me; otherwise, I wouldn't be able to communicate with Emlyn... Klein seemed to gain an understanding.]

["I became acquainted with a doctor who's good at treating lung diseases, so I've asked him to come and give you a checkup. Let me do the introductions. This is Dr. Emlyn White."

"Is that so? You still actually remembered this? What a good child!" Doris happily invited the two inside.

Child... Klein's mouth twitched, but he didn't say anything in the end.]

Emlyn examined Doris and explained to Jurgen her condition, advising him to move with her to a place with warm and fresh air. He also offered them some medicine he had prepared, but he told Klein that it could only give her a few more years to live, as the problem was too severe for any medicine to cure. Jurgen was just happy to see his grandmother already starting to look livelier.

Chapter 372: Missing Case

Klein and Emlyn didn't stay for long before walking back to Klein's home.

[Emlyn White thought for a second, lowered his voice, and said in deliberation, “Last night, I thought over things for a long time and found out that you actually didn’t do anything, so why are you asking for compensation? That old man would’ve let me leave at any moment.”

Klein chuckled. “No, that’s not how the accounts are done. Your parents assigned a mission to find you, not to save you. In the end, I found you. According to the agreement, the reward should belong to me. “Besides, if I hadn’t reminded you, you might’ve stayed in Harvest Church for weeks or months before you realized that you were free to leave. Furthermore, you wouldn’t have noticed the seed planted in your mind.”

“Are you hinting that my intelligence isn’t up to par?” Emlyn’s face twisted.

No, I’m saying it directly... Klein smiled but didn’t say anything else.]

On Thursday morning, Klein went to East Borough so Kohler could report the situation to him. He learned that there were people trying to spread the belief in the “creator of everything”, with Klein suspecting that this was being done by the Aurora Order. He couldn’t guess their purpose, but the situation had probably already reached the churches.

He also learned that the workers who were protesting had failed, and many of them lost their jobs. Kohler then told Klein about the laundry maid, named Liv, that they encountered last time; her youngest daughter, Daisy, was missing, so Klein asked Kohler to take him to her.

Elsewhere, Fors was taking a walk for inspiration about her next novel when she found herself having walked all the way to the apartment of the old woman who had made her a Beyonder. There, she found an old man repeatedly ringing the bell, puzzled that no one was answering. When he noticed her, he asked if she knew people named Laubero and Aulisa, and she informed him that they passed away years ago.

[After a moment of silence, he said, “Thank you, good lady. I am the elder brother of Laubero, and I’ve been living in Midseashire all this time. As I haven’t received any letters from them for a long time, I decided to come and pay them a visit. Can you tell me what happened to them in the past few years?”

Mrs. Aulisa’s husband’s elder brother... Could he be a descendant of the family she spoke of? Fors suddenly snapped to her senses and replied with a smile, “No problem.”]

In East Borough, Klein reached Liv’s home, finding her lifelessly doing her work, with her eldest daughter crying in guilt at her younger sister’s disappearance.

Chapter 373: Search

Liv was untrusting and hostile toward Klein, telling him that she already made a police report and didn’t need the help of a detective.

[Klein looked back at the laundry maid, Liv, and said in a neutral tone, “Do you believe that the East Borough police will really be looking for Daisy? Are you sure the people who caused Daisy to go ‘missing’ wouldn’t cast their sights on your family? Do you wish to lose another daughter after losing one?”

When the cruel yet heart-wrenching words reached Liv's ears, the indifferent expression on her face slowly crumbled. She turned agape, but she couldn't say anything. The corners of her eyes gradually turned red. She abruptly lowered her head and muttered to herself in pain and despair, "I don't have any money..."]

After convincing her that he didn't want to take money to help, Liv and her daughter started telling him about Daisy's disappearance: the two sisters were out to deliver some clothes, passing through small, dark alleys. When the eldest got momentarily distracted, she turned to find Daisy gone. Klein asked if they had anything that belonged to Daisy, anything she kept with her often.

[Suddenly, she blinked and said, "Wait, there's something. Daisy's vocabulary book!"

"Vocabulary book?" Old Kohler asked.

Liv sniffed and said, "I make Freja and Daisy attend the free school at night. I can keep washing clothes, but they can't always be doing the same."

This lady is such a good mother... Klein couldn't help but sigh.]

Klein took the vocabulary book, asked Kohler to keep watching the situation with the people who lost their jobs, then bid his farewells. Using the book as a medium, he used divination while riding a carriage and found himself at a large house with a lawn in an area close to the one he lived in. He didn't go in, as his intuition told him there was great danger inside, but he learned that this house belonged to someone named Capim.

[Klein suddenly remembered who Capim was. There were many rumors that he was the leader of a bloody criminal organization which was stained with blood. He was involved in the disappearance of many innocent girls!]

In a coffee shop elsewhere, Fors learned that the old man was named Lawrence. She vaguely told him about being Aulisa's doctor and inheriting everything the woman left behind, though she didn't mention anything about mysticism or Beyonders. He asked about where the two were buried, and Fors left after telling him.

[After sitting down again, he rubbed his temples in distress and silently muttered to himself, *Laubero is dead, and he didn't leave any children behind, and I don't know what Aulisa did to his Beyonder characteristic... Richard died at the hands of the Aurora Order... Sam doesn't even wish to contact us at all, having no interest in shouldering the responsibility of the family name...*

Will the Abraham family slowly disappear like this?]

Chapter 374: Artificial Sleepwalking

The Abraham family, whose members couldn't advance beyond Sequence 8 without dying thanks to the curse, had taken to having a master-apprentice inheritance system: they would train people who weren't from the Abraham family in the hopes that, once they advanced enough without having to worry about being affected by the curse, they would be able to eliminate it and maybe even find Bethel Abraham.

Many of the apprentices reached Sequence 6 and 5, and they started getting ambitious and greedy, setting their eyes on the Sealed Artifact that the Abraham family possessed, believing themselves worthier of them. One of them, named Botis, ended up joining the Aurora Order and causing a disaster that led to the death of many of the leaders of the Abraham family, along with the loss of many Sealed Artifacts, with only 3 being left. With everything he stole, Botis successfully advanced to Sequence 4.

After returning home, Fors prayed to The Fool to inform him of her encounter with Lawrence, adding that she feared him being a Beyonder and using divination to find out everything she didn't tell him. Klein taught her an "artificial sleepwalking" ritual that he could use to shield her from divination.

Just like with the secret deed ritual, he touched the Black Emperor Card of Blasphemy to elevate his level, but he directed the gray fog to a paper figurine he had. The figurine grew in size and also had twelve pairs of black wings on its back. It enveloped Fors with them before disappearing.

Chapter 375: An "Evil god's" Impressive Act

Fors was surprised at The Fool sending an "angel" to protect her, and she started theorizing about which ancient being he could be. With this done, Klein used divination to see Daisy's situation, receiving many scenes: Daisy getting kidnapped by a man in a remote alley when her sister was elsewhere, Daisy in a dark room with cries and screams reaching her, Daisy being abused as she called out for her mother and sister.

Klein composed himself as he wondered why his intuition had warned him; that would be the case if there were Sequence 6 or 5 Beyonders involved, but why would they? This was just a human trafficking case that didn't require anything stronger than Sequence 7. Divination showed that trying to save Daisy was a highly dangerous matter, but not hopelessly so.

[He leaned back in his chair, closed his eyes, and said with a self-deprecating smile, *Wasn't I looking for an opportunity to perform? This is it! As a Magician, I have to challenge something of a higher difficulty. Otherwise, I would be called a Trickmaster and not a Magician. Completing the seemingly impossible, even if the outcome is nothing but an illusion, that's the image of a magician in my heart. As for whether it's one of the principles or not, I still need confirmation...*]

The biggest issue was that Klein knew nothing about Capim or the Beyonders and traps he might have in his villa, which made doing the necessary preparations impossible. He would have to do some investigating first.

In the afternoon, Klein summoned himself and, in his Spirit Body state, waited close to Capim's villa. When a man walked out of it, Klein possessed him and walked him to a room in a random hotel so he could be free to question the man and summon his spirit. He knocked the man out then came to the room in his physical body. As Klein was preparing to summon his spirit, he found that the man had a sort of seal on him, which meant that Klein's attempts to extract information would only end up alerting the enemy.

That, however, wouldn't stop Klein. Summoning himself once again, he possessed the man and made him recite The Fool's Honorific Name.